

SDG Goal 6

Clean water and sanitation

SDG Target 6.3

By 2030, improve water quality by reducing pollution, eliminating dumping and minimizing release of hazardous chemicals and materials, halving the proportion of untreated wastewater and substantially increasing recycling and safe reuse globally

SDG Indicator 6.3.2

Proportion of bodies of water with good ambient water quality

Time series

Ecological status of water bodies

1. General information on the time series

- Date of national metadata: March 25, 2026
- National data: <https://sdg-indicators.de/6-3-2>
- Definition: The time series shows the ecological status of water bodies (rivers, lakes, and transitional and coastal waters of the North Sea and the Baltic Sea).
- Disaggregation: Type of water body, status class

2. Comparability with the UN metadata

- Date of UN metadata: July 2024
- UN metadata: <https://unstats.un.org/sdgs/metadata/files/Metadata-06-03-02.pdf>
- The time series is not compliant with the UN metadata, but provides additional information. The condition of the water bodies under investigation is assessed primarily on the basis of biological indicators rather than physical and chemical parameters.

3. Data description

- The data comes from the Federal Environment Agency. The ecological status of water bodies is regularly assessed as part of a monitoring program and documented in management plans. These plans are based on the six-year management cycle of the Water Framework Directive. The second management cycle began in December 2015 and ended in December 2021. During this period, a portion of the water bodies was assessed each year. Another six-year cycle will follow, ending in 2027.

To determine the ecological status of a water body, the species composition of selected plant and animal communities is primarily analyzed and compared with the population that would naturally be present in the corresponding water body type. Four groups of organisms are analyzed for this assessment: invertebrates living on the water body's bottom (macrozoobenthos), aquatic plants (macrophytes) and algae attached to the bottom (phytobenthos), floating algae (phytoplankton), and fish. Depending on the degree of deviation from the natural state, five status classes are assigned: from "very good" to "poor." The biological quality element with the lowest rating determines the overall status of a water body.

Furthermore, if the national environmental quality standard (UQN) for a relevant pollutant is exceeded, the ecological status can, at best, be rated as moderate. For the assessment and to indicate pollution levels, additional physicochemical parameters

such as nutrient content, temperature, or salinity, as well as hydromorphological parameters—that is, characteristics relating to the form of a watercourse—are used in the case of flowing waters.

For artificial and significantly altered lakes or watercourses, the “ecological potential” is assessed. The highest potential is achieved when all measures to improve ecological quality have been implemented that do not significantly negatively impact uses.

4. Access to data source

- Ecological status of rivers:
<https://www.umweltbundesamt.de/en/data/environmental-indicators/indicator-ecological-status-of-rivers>
- Ecological status of lakes:
<https://www.umweltbundesamt.de/en/data/environmental-indicators/indicator-ecological-status-of-lakes>
- Ecological status of transitional and coastal waters:
<https://www.umweltbundesamt.de/en/data/environmental-indicators/indicator-ecological-status-of-transitional-coastal>

5. Metadata on source data

- Ecological status of running waters - Methodology (only available in German):
<https://www.umweltbundesamt.de/daten/wasser/fliesssgewaesser/oekologischer-zustand-der-fliesssgewaesser#methode>
- Status of lakes (only available in German):
<https://www.umweltbundesamt.de/daten/wasser/zustand-der-seen#bewertungsmethodik>
- Ecological status of transitional and coastal waters - North sea (only available in German):
<https://www.umweltbundesamt.de/daten/wasser/nordsee/oekologischer-zustand-der-uebergangs#bewertungsmethode->
- Ecological status of coastal waters - Baltic sea (only available in German):
<https://www.umweltbundesamt.de/daten/wasser/ostsee/oekologischer-zustand-der-uebergangs#bewertungsmethode>

6. Timeliness and frequency

- Timeliness: Not applicable.
- Frequency: Every 7 years

7. Calculation method

- Unit of measurement: Percent
- Calculation: Not applicable.